

PAL Leader Training

A blended approach: online learning and in-person practice

Building knowledge online → applying it in practice

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Two-Part Training Approach

1. Online Training - Building Knowledge

- Completed independently before the in-person session
- Introduces the PAL model, principles and core expectations
- Develops understanding of facilitation, planning, boundaries and online delivery
- Includes short knowledge checks to reinforce learning

2. In-Person Training - Putting it into Practice

- Interactive and practical
- Group discussion and facilitation exercises
- Scenario-based activities and session planning
- Opportunities to practise delivering PAL activities and receive feedback

Online training develops the knowledge → In-person training provides the opportunity to practise and apply it.

Online PAL Leader Training

The online element is structured to provide consistent core knowledge before the practical in-person training.

Unit 1

PAL Model & Principles

What PAL is, its history and principles, benefits of PAL and the PAL Leader role.

Unit 2

Leadership & Facilitation

Skills for leading groups, encouraging participation and facilitating peer learning.

Unit 3

Planning & Evaluating PAL

Planning effective sessions and reflecting on and evaluating PAL delivery.

Unit 4

Boundaries & Relationships

Understanding the role, maintaining boundaries and knowing when to signpost.

Unit 5

Delivering PAL Online

Adapting PAL principles and facilitation techniques for online sessions.

Unit 1: The PAL Model and Principles

This unit establishes a consistent understanding of PAL before Leaders move into practical skills.

Unit Content

- Introduces what PAL is, how it works and briefly introduce its history.
- We set out the purpose of PAL within student learning.
- This gives every Leader the same starting point, regardless of the module they will support.

The PAL Approach

- Introduces the core PAL principles rather than expecting Leaders to infer the role.
- Emphasises collaborative, student-led learning.
- We distinguish PAL from teaching or tutoring and reinforce student independence.

The PAL Leader Role

- Outlines what PAL Leaders are expected to do and the benefits of the role.
- Introduces the idea of guiding learning rather than providing answers.
- We finish with a short knowledge check to confirm the key messages.

Knowledge Check

A short quiz at the end of the unit

Example Questions

Question 1

2 points ...

What is Peer Assisted Learning also known as? (Select all that apply)

- ☒ A. Supplemental Instruction Correct answer
- ☒ B. Peer Assisted Study Sessions Correct answer
- ☐ C. Student Instruction
- ☐ D. Peer Study Support Service
- ☐ E. Student Teaching

Question 2

5 points ...

True or False?

"PAL can benefit all students regardless of their different academic abilities"

- ☒ True Correct answer
- ☐ False

Unit 2: Leadership and Facilitation

This unit shows Leaders how to lead and guide PAL sessions and introduces techniques they can later practise face-to-face.

Guiding Rather Than Teaching

- Introduces the difference between facilitating and lecturing.
- Introduces collaborative methods and activities that keep students active.
- Shows how PAL Leaders can guide learning without becoming the subject teacher.

Questioning Techniques

- Compares open and closed questions.
- Introduces wait time, redirecting questions and checking for understanding.
- Examples show how Leaders can return questions to the group rather than immediately giving answers.

Managing Participation

- Discuss how approaches change with large, small or very small groups.
- Introduces pairs, sub-groups and structured interaction.
- The aim is to give Leaders a toolkit before they practise these techniques in person.

Knowledge Check

A short quiz at the end of the unit reinforces the key facilitation principles.

Example Questions

Matching

Source: Generated bank (Questioning in your session) 22/03/2024

Match the following prompts with their correct answers:

Prompt	Answer		
① What do you think about..?	Asking for someone's opinion	Partial: 25%	Negative: -25%
② What would happen if..?	Exploring potential outcomes	Partial: 25%	Negative: -25%
③ Why do you think this happened..?	Investigating causes	Partial: 25%	Negative: -25%
④ How do you think we could..?	Generating solutions	Partial: 25%	Negative: -25%
Distractors			
① When was this discovered?			

Multiple Choice

Source: Generated bank (Managing student numbers) 22/03/2024

What is one way to manage a very large group of students in a PAL session?

- ☐ A. Cancel the session
- ☐ B. Reduce the planned activities
- ☐ C. Keep the group together at all times
- ☒ D. Divide them into subgroups

Correct answer

What the Quiz Checks

- Understanding the difference between facilitating and lecturing
- Appropriate use of open questions
- Redirecting questions to promote independence
- Selecting collaborative learning activities
- Adapting facilitation to different group sizes

Unit 3: Planning and Evaluating PAL

This unit takes Leaders through the full PAL session cycle: preparation, structure, evaluation and reflection.

Preparing and Planning

- Shows Leaders how to use Blackboard/course materials when preparing.
- Introduces planning around objectives, questions, activities and resources.
- Provides a clear session structure rather than leaving Leaders to design sessions from scratch.

Session Structure

- We break a PAL session into opening, main activity and closing stages.
- We include discussion prompts, such as how Leaders would explain PAL to new students.
- Emphasises flexibility because student needs and attendance can change.

Evaluation and Reflection

- Introduces attendance recording and student evaluation responsibilities.
- Introduces reflection after each session: what worked, what did not and what to change.
- Debriefs and feedback are presented as part of continuous improvement, not an add-on.

Knowledge Check

The unit ends with a short quiz to reinforce planning, evaluation and reflective practice.

Example Questions

When planning your session, what do we suggest to do first?

- ☒ A. Break down the lecture topic into key areas to cover
- ☐ B. Decide activities for the session
- ☐ C. Decide what the icebreaker will be

Correct answer

What is the estimated time given for the 'middle' section of the PAL session (when the main activities take place)?

- ☐ A. 20 minutes
- ☒ B. 30 minutes
- ☐ C. 40 minutes

Correct answer

Outside of the PAL session, what else do you need to do as a PAL Leader? (Select all that apply)

- ☒ A. Plan future PAL sessions
- ☐ B. Answer student queries via email
- ☒ C. Attend debrief meetings
- ☐ D. Meet with students to provide support outside of the PAL session

Correct answer

Correct answer

What the Quiz Checks

- Effective preparation and use of course resources
- Session structure and time management
- Positive opening and closing techniques
- Understanding of attendance and evaluation responsibilities
- Reflection, flexibility and continuous improvement

Unit 4: Boundaries and Relationships

Boundaries are introduced online so Leaders understand their responsibilities before applying them to realistic scenarios in person.

Roles and Relationships

- Clarifies PAL Leader responsibilities and the role of PAL Coordinators.
- Covers appropriate relationships with lecturers and PAL Leaders.
- Clear do/don't examples make the limits of the role explicit.

Signposting and Boundaries

- Introduces when an issue sits outside the PAL Leader role.
- Introduces referral and signposting routes to university services.
- Leaders learn that seeking support is an appropriate part of the role.

Behaviour and Difficult Situations

- Introduces approaches to different student behaviours.
- Covers challenging situations and emergency expectations.
- The online content provides the knowledge that is later applied through scenarios in the in-person training.

Knowledge Check

A short quiz checks that PAL Leaders understand boundaries, relationships, signposting and escalation.

Example Questions

Question 1

2 points ...

What should you do if you think you need a bit more training?

- ☒ A. Raise it with the PAL Coordinator (Learning Services)
- ☐ B. Raise it with the Subject Lead (Academic)
- ☐ C. Don't raise it - you will hopefully work it out

Correct answer

Question 4

6 points ...

What should you NOT do as a PAL Leader? (Select all that apply)

- ☐ A. provide straightforward responses
- ☐ B. be friendly towards students
- ☒ C. argue with students
- ☒ D. provide relationship advice
- ☒ E. pretend to know the answer
- ☐ F. refer the student to further support

Correct answer

Correct answer

Correct answer

What the Quiz Checks

- Understanding of PAL Leader responsibilities
- Appropriate relationships with lecturers and PAL Leaders
- Professional boundaries and ground rules
- Effective referral and signposting
- Responding appropriately to challenging situations and emergencies

Optional Unit: Delivering PAL Online

This optional extension supports Leaders who may deliver PAL online; it is not required for everyone.

Unit Content

- Introduces Blackboard Collaborate and the basic online session environment.
- Leaders see how to prepare the virtual space and share materials.
- The focus is on the tools needed to support PAL rather than technical training in isolation.

Online Interaction Tools

- Shows how polls can be used for participation and understanding checks.
- Introduces breakout rooms for pair and small-group work.
- Activities are linked back to the same collaborative PAL principles used on campus.

Campus vs Online

- Compares how interaction works in the two environments.
- We highlight where communication and activities may need adapting.
- The key message is: adapt the method and tools, not the purpose of PAL.



Part 2: In-Person PAL Leader Training

Using face-to-face time to apply, practise and contextualise the online learning

Application • Practice • Confidence

How the In-Person Training Works

The face-to-face session builds on the online units rather than repeating them.

Connect & Contextualise

- Introductions and a short icebreaker help Leaders connect with their PAL partners.
- The purpose of PAL is briefly revisited.
- The local scheme, timetable and practical expectations are clarified.

Apply the Online Learning

- Key topics are revisited through discussion rather than re-taught.
- Boundary scenarios require Leaders to decide when to help, signpost or seek support.
- Questioning techniques are applied to realistic PAL situations.

Practise Before Delivery

- Leaders plan a sample PAL session.
- They practise guiding activities, questioning and board work.
- Feedback focuses on student involvement, confidence and readiness.

Making the Training Scheme-Specific

Generic PAL principles are connected to the practical arrangements Leaders need for their own scheme.

Scheme Information

- Modules supported and how PAL fits within the programme.
- Session times, locations and how students access PAL.
- How Leaders are paired or grouped for delivery.

Leader Responsibilities

- Planning with PAL partners and attending scheduled sessions.
- Recording attendance and sharing the evaluation survey.
- Communication, debrief meetings and feedback.

Applying the Learning in Practice

Three practical activities turn the online content into decisions and behaviours Leaders can use in real sessions.

1. Boundary Scenarios

- Small groups discuss realistic student situations.
- They decide: Is this within the PAL role? Should the student be signposted?
- Example: “What would you say if a student asked for help outside your role?”

2. Question & Redirect

- Leaders practise open questions, wait time and redirecting.
- Example: “How would you approach this?”
- Instead of answering: “What do you think?” or “Does anyone else have an idea?”

3. Plan a PAL Activity

- Leaders plan a short opening, collaborative activity and closing.
- The plan must involve students rather than reproduce a lecture.
- Discussion considers different group sizes and resources.

Preparing Leaders for Delivery

The final part focuses on practising delivery and making sure Leaders know what happens next.

- **Peers identify what encouraged participation.**

- Feedback considers clarity, questioning and how well students were involved.
- Leaders can refine their approach before their first PAL session.

Practice Delivery

- Leaders guide a short activity or board-work task.
- The focus is on questioning, participation and student explanation.
- Slides may support an activity, but should not become another lecture.

Practical Arrangement

- Confirm timetable, room, resources and PAL partner.
- Know how attendance and evaluation will be collected.
- Know who to contact and how ongoing debrief/support will work.

Ready to Start

- Give students something to work on.
- Use individual, pair, small-group or whole-class activities.
- Ask students to give answers and explain their reasoning.

Key Principles of the Training Model

A clear division of purpose keeps the training consistent, practical and adaptable.

Online Training

Core knowledge and expectations are established online.

In-Person Training

Leaders practise questioning, planning and guiding activities before delivery.

Key ideas are revisited through realistic scenarios and discussion.